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Independent Study Proposal - IS 901

Edo Echoes: Interactive Cultural Adaptation and Fictive Worldbuilding through Twine

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Project Overview

This independent study supports the development of an original interactive fiction project by Noel Nova that explores Japanese Edo-period culture through historical research, narrative adaptation, and interactive game design. The project will culminate in a Twine-based non-linear game that transforms selected historical and cultural materials into a fictive narrative environment.

Conducted under the aegis of the Center for Holistic Integration (CHI) at New York City College of Technology, CUNY, the study is situated within a broader interdisciplinary research framework that integrates creative practice, technology, collaboration, and cultural inquiry. Within that context, Mr. Nova's project contributes to ongoing CHI investigations into narrative systems, cultural transformation, interactive media, and blended storytelling environments.

Rather than attempting to reproduce historical events directly, the study will explore how historical narratives, cultural practices, and symbolic systems can be respectfully transformed into a parallel fictive environment. In this way, the project brings together cultural research, narrative design, game development, and worldbuilding as a single interdisciplinary creative endeavor.

Project Concept

The central concept of this independent study is the creation of a playable narrative experience inspired by Japanese Edo-period history and UNESCO-recognized cultural traditions. During the planning discussion, several possible cultural influences were suggested, including:

- *Kabuki* theatre
- *Bunraku* puppet theatre
- *Fururi Odori* ritual dances
- *Washi* paper craftsmanship
- Edo-period political and social narratives
- Historical transitions surrounding the Tokugawa Shogunate

Particular attention was given to Bunraku puppet theatre because of its conceptual relationship to the Blended Shadow Puppet initiative and broader CHI work in puppetry, storytelling, mediated performance, and symbolic environments.

The resulting game is not envisioned as a historical simulation, but as an act of cultural transformation. Its themes, tensions, aesthetics, and symbolic structures will be reimagined within CHI's existing Shadow world. Developed over several years through the contributions of multiple students, researchers, and related creative projects, this evolving narrative environment provides a broader collaborative context for the work while allowing

the project to remain recognizably informed by its source material and grounded in respect for the traditions from which it draws.

Academic and Creative Objectives

The independent study has several interconnected objectives:

1. Conduct focused research into selected Edo-period cultural practices, historical events, or artistic traditions.
2. Investigate UNESCO intangible cultural heritage materials and their relationship to narrative, ritual, and performance systems.
3. Develop methods for adapting historical and cultural material into fictive narrative environments.
4. Design and implement a non-linear interactive fiction experience using Twine.
5. Explore player agency and knowledge-driven gameplay through branching narrative structures.
6. Contribute a new narrative artifact to the growing Blended Shadow Puppet fictive universe, which serves as a beneficiary and integration framework for CHI's UNESCO-related cultural research projects.
7. Develop professional documentation and project management practices using GitHub-based workflows.

Research Methodology

The project will proceed through several overlapping methodological components that move from cultural and historical inquiry into narrative transformation and finally into interactive implementation. It will begin with focused research into selected Edo-period materials and related cultural traditions, continue through the adaptation of those materials into CHI's broader Shadow world and collaborative narrative framework, and culminate in the design and development of a Twine-based interactive fiction experience. Across these stages, the study will combine research, interpretation, worldbuilding, and iterative creative development as interconnected parts of a single methodological process.

1. Cultural and Historical Research

Noel will identify a specific narrative framework, cultural practice, historical moment, or symbolic structure from the Edo period as the basis for adaptation. Research may include:

- UNESCO cultural heritage documentation
- Historical analysis
- Artistic and theatrical traditions
- Ritual practices
- Social and political structures
- Traditional craft systems
- Music and performance traditions

Research notes and references will be documented throughout development. All research notes will be stored in a GitHub repository, and all research references will be stored in Zotero.

2. Narrative Transformation

After identifying a suitable source narrative or cultural structure, Noel will adapt the material into a parallel fictive world framework. As discussed during the planning meeting, this process involves preserving the structural essence of the original while shifting it into a transformed symbolic context.

The adaptation process may involve:

- Renaming locations and characters
- Reframing political structures
- Translating symbolic systems
- Modifying cosmology or mythology
- Embedding cultural references into fictional environments

The goal is not imitation, but respectful transformation.

3. Interactive Narrative Development

The final work will be implemented using Twine as the primary delivery platform. The game will emphasize:

- Branching narrative pathways
- Meaningful player choice
- Knowledge acquisition and discovery
- Exploration-based interaction
- Narrative consequence

The project will specifically avoid purely linear storytelling structures. During the meeting discussion, Noel and Dr. Smith emphasized that player decisions should produce meaningful shifts in understanding and narrative outcome.

Deliverables

The independent study will produce the following deliverables:

Primary Deliverables

1. A completed Twine-based interactive fiction game
2. A narrative integration document describing the fictive world adaptation
3. A brief reflective report documenting research, development process, and design decisions

Supporting Deliverables

- GitHub repository with project documentation, development notes, branching diagrams, and archived worldbuilding materials
- Zotero library of research references and source materials
- World Anvil entries or related contributions to CHI's Shadow world, as appropriate
- Visual or conceptual assets supporting the project's fictive world development

Technical Framework

The project will use Twine as its primary development platform for building and presenting the interactive work. GitHub will support documentation, organization, version tracking, and archival recordkeeping, while Zotero will be used to manage research references and source materials. World Anvil may also be used, as appropriate, to support contributions to CHI's existing Shadow world and its broader collaborative worldbuilding framework. As part of the study, Noel will also be onboarded into the broader CHI research and project ecosystem.

The project may additionally involve branching logic systems, narrative flow mapping, hypertext structures, interactive dialogue systems, embedded media assets, and experimental worldbuilding structures, depending on the final scope of development.

Relationship to CHI and the CHI Ecosystem

This project aligns with larger CHI investigations into:

- Narrative transformation
- Cultural adaptation
- Blended storytelling systems
- Interactive media

- Puppet and theatrical traditions
- Symbolic environments
- Human-machine collaborative creativity

The project also contributes to the evolving CHI narrative framework by expanding it through a culturally grounded interactive artifact.

The study therefore operates simultaneously as:

- an individual creative work,
- a research exercise in cultural transformation,
- and a contribution to a larger collaborative narrative ecosystem.

Mentorship and Workflow

Dr. Smith will provide project supervision throughout the independent study, offering narrative and research guidance, structural feedback, technical consultation, and administrative support as the work develops. His role will be to help shape the project both conceptually and practically, ensuring that Noel's research, design process, and final implementation remain aligned with the broader aims of the study and with CHI's collaborative research environment.

Initial project setup will include completion of IS901 paperwork, GitHub repository setup, onboarding into the CHI research and project ecosystem, and development of the initial scope document. Because Dr. Smith will be physically unavailable during portions of June, mentorship meetings may take place through Zoom and asynchronous review workflows as needed.

Assessment

Assessment will emphasize:

- quality and depth of research,
- effectiveness of cultural adaptation,
- sophistication of interactive narrative structure,
- completeness of documentation,
- integration of feedback,
- and successful completion of the playable Twine experience.

Special emphasis will be placed on Noel's ability to synthesize research and creative design into a coherent interactive world.

Conclusion

This independent study provides Noel Nova with the opportunity to complete a substantial interdisciplinary capstone experience combining cultural research, fictive worldbuilding, interactive storytelling, and game development.

By investigating Edo-period Japanese cultural traditions and transforming them into a playable narrative environment, the project bridges historical research and speculative design while contributing to broader CHI initiatives. The resulting work will function both as a standalone creative artifact and as part of a larger framework exploring narrative, symbolic systems, and collaborative worldbuilding.

The project is intentionally designed to support Noel's transition from culminating academic work into independent creative practice while producing a polished and meaningful final contribution prior to graduation in September 2026.